

Repentance as a Lifestyle

“Turn to God, and do works meet for repentance.” — Acts 26:20

Introduction

What if repentance isn't the thing you do when you've failed—but the direction you're always facing?

Jeremiah lamented the fall of Israel to Babylon. Yet he remembered that the Lord's mercies would preserve His people despite captivity and suffering: “His compassions fail not. They are new every morning” (Lamentations 3:21–23). When we individually fall to “Babylon” and sin to any degree throughout our lives, we must not despair and give up hope. We must not deny our pain or shame with cheap comforts. True repentance is a deliberate spiritual act—faith as a stubborn choice to turn to God, Who is “ready to pardon, gracious and merciful, slow to anger, and of great kindness” (Nehemiah 9:17; Psalm 86:5; Isaiah 55:7; Ezekiel 18:21–23; Ezekiel 33:11).

Card 1 · The Daily Turn

Acts 26:20 · Luke 9:23 · Mosiah 4:11–12 · John 8:11

How We Practice — Repentance as a Direction, Not an Emergency

Repenting of our sins should feel as vital and normal to disciples of Christ as breathing, eating, and possessing a beating heart. We do not wait for a great fall to turn back to God; we turn daily, in the small course-corrections of an honest life. Paul described the whole of discipleship in four plain words—“do works meet for repentance” (Acts 26:20)—and the word disciple itself shares its root with discipline: a disciple of Christ is a devoted student who practices, and keeps practicing, what the Master teaches (John 8:31).

Repentance kept daily is not a burden of endless guilt; it is the ordinary rhythm by which God changes us from the inside out. Jesus provided the divine pattern: “If any man will come after me, let him deny himself, and take up his cross daily, and follow me” (Luke 9:23). The daily

lifestyle of honest personal accounting and humble repentance before God nourishes one's spirit to a lively state of being.

This is why King Benjamin's people did not repent once and move on. They were told to call "on the name of the Lord daily" so they might "always retain a remission" of their sins (Mosiah 4:11–12). "Yea, and as often as my people repent will I forgive them their trespasses" (Mosiah 26:30).

In connection with this principle of repentance, we remember the Lord's paired statements to the woman taken in adultery—the pardon, "Neither do I condemn thee," and the charge, "Go, and sin no more" (John 8:11). We cannot be perfected in a day. We cannot climb to God by our own strength. We simply keep turning to Him in repentance, taking up our cross daily, and let Him change us from within, throughout our lives, until that "perfect day" (Proverbs 4:18).

How It Blesses — Still Growing, Still Turning

I made covenants to follow Jesus Christ, but I have learned that keeping them is not a single victory but a daily return to God. I seek to maintain the forgiveness of my sins through continued repentance. I am still growing as an individual—and that is not a confession of failure but a description of the lifestyle of a disciple of Christ. The turning never graduates into something I've outgrown; turning to Christ daily, it is the walk.

The promise attached to this daily turning is not exhaustion but rest. "Come unto me, all ye that labour and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest" (Matthew 11:28). The rhythm God asks of us is one He sustains.

Wherever repentance currently sits in your life—a rare emergency, a Sunday ritual, or a daily habit—the commitment below invites you to take one honest step toward making it the direction you face.

How Will You Practice?

COVENANT

I will end each day this week with a brief accounting before God—naming what I need to set right, and asking for His help to turn—so that repentance becomes daily, not occasional.

SEEKER

I will take five quiet minutes each evening this week to ask myself one honest question: Which direction am I facing?

EXPLORE

I will pause once this week to reflect on one thing I would change about how I'm living, without judgment—just honesty.

REFLECTION. *What would change if turning back to God were as ordinary to you as catching your breath?*

Card 2 · Godly Sorrow

2 Corinthians 7:10 · Mosiah 4:2–3

How We Practice — The Sorrow That Leads Somewhere

The word repent comes to us through Middle English from Latin roots, and its meaning is to feel deep sorrow. There can be no true repentance where there is no true sorrow—but not every sorrow heals. Paul drew the line precisely: "godly sorrow worketh repentance to salvation... but the sorrow of the world worketh death" (2 Corinthians 7:10). Worldly sorrow is the shame and resentment at being caught and found guilty of sin; it can only condemn—it circles the same regret and calls it penance. Godly sorrow moves—it motivates one to reach toward God, toward change, toward mercy.

Godly sorrow carries five marks: honesty enough to admit our errors; depth of character enough to feel the weight of sin; humility enough to accept our need to be forgiven; a real desire to change and to keep trying; and faith that God is merciful and gracious enough to forgive us. Notice where it ends—not in self-loathing, but in faith. King Benjamin's people, struck by exactly this sorrow, cried out for mercy and were filled with joy and the peace of conscience (Mosiah 4:2–3). Sorrow was the doorway; it was never meant to be the room we live in.

How It Blesses — When Guilt Becomes Grace

I have known both kinds of sorrow in my own heart. There were seasons I mistook shame or embarrassment for repentance—reliving the same regret over and over, which changed nothing within me—bitter waters that cannot satisfy thirst. I have also become acquainted with the other kind of sorrow, the kind that finally moved me: quieter, honest, inspired, and strangely hopeful, because it pointed me toward God instead of away from Him. Scripture promises that this second sorrow is safe to feel: it works "repentance to salvation not to be repented of" (2 Corinthians 7:10). You will never regret having grieved your sins honestly

before God and having made sincere efforts to "do works meet for repentance" (Acts 26:20). He is faithful to forgive us, to heal us, and to rejoice in our return to fellowship with Him.

The commitment below is not about manufacturing guilt. It is about letting honest sorrow do its proper work—and then setting it down.

How Will You Practice?

COVENANT

I will bring one specific sin before God this week in honest sorrow—naming it plainly, asking forgiveness, and then receiving His mercy rather than rehearsing my shame.

SEEKER

I will notice this week when I am circling a regret without moving, and I will ask God to turn that feeling into one real step of change.

EXPLORE

I will reflect once this week on the difference between feeling bad about something and actually deciding to change it.

REFLECTION. *Is there a sorrow you have been carrying in circles that God is inviting you to carry toward Him instead?*

Card 3 · Confess and Forsake

D&C 58:42–43 · James 5:16

How We Practice — The Anatomy of a Real Turning

Sorrow begins repentance; it does not complete it. The Lord's own measure of a true turning is plain: "By this ye may know if a man repenteth of his sins—behold, he will confess them and forsake them" (D&C 58:43). Both verbs matter. To confess is to stop hiding and name the wrong before God—and, when we have injured someone, before them. To forsake is to commit to a path of change so that, in time, we no longer return to the sin.

Elder Robert D. Hales taught that the depth of our repentance should match the severity of our sin. After recognizing and mourning what we have done, we pray to ask God's forgiveness; we commit to change; and where we have harmed another, we apologize and, if possible, make restitution. For sins of a more serious nature—or when we simply cannot seem to break free—God has provided inspired help: we may confess to a trusted religious leader and ask for

guidance (James 5:16). Confession to a leader is not humiliation; it is a lifeline the Lord Himself extends. The Lord has promised that of the sins we confess and forsake, He "will remember them no more" (D&C 58:42).

How It Blesses — The Weight You No Longer Carry

The hardest step for me has never been feeling sorry. It has been saying it out loud—to God plainly, and to the person I had wronged. Yet every time I have stopped hiding a thing and named it, the thing I thought I was hiding turned out to be the weight I was carrying. Confession did not cost me my peace. It gave it back.

The commitment below invites one concrete act of confessing or forsaking—the step that turns sorrow into freedom.

How Will You Practice?

COVENANT

I will complete one repentance fully this week—confessing it to God, making any needed apology or restitution, and, if the matter is serious, seeking counsel from a trusted religious leader.

SEEKER

I will name one thing I have been hiding—to God, and if someone was hurt, to them—and take one step to set it right.

EXPLORE

I will write down one thing I would like to stop doing, and one small, concrete step I could take away from it this week.

REFLECTION. *Is there something you have been keeping in the dark that would lose its weight the moment you brought it into the light?*

Card 4 · Sanctified Line Upon Line

Mosiah 5:2 · Ezekiel 33:16 · Philippians 2:12–13

How We Practice — Becoming, Bit by Bit

Repentance kept daily does something slow and beautiful over a life. As it becomes part of our daily personal religion, we gradually commit fewer and less severe sins; the depth of remorse

we must feel grows lighter; and the stretches of happiness and freedom from guilt grow longer and more frequent. This is sanctification—to become pure and holy—and it comes not in a single leap but line upon line, across the whole length of our days. It is possible only through a meek and humble willingness to acknowledge our own wrongdoing, and it is "aided by the power of the Spirit of God."

Here is the truth that keeps this from becoming a burden: grace is not the reward at the end of repentance; it is the power that makes repentance possible. We "work out" our salvation "with fear and trembling" precisely because "it is God which worketh in [us]" (Philippians 2:12–13). The spiritual fruits of repentance can be so profound that we begin to have "no more disposition to do evil, but to do good continually" (Mosiah 5:2). And of the sins we have truly forsaken, the Lord promises they "shall not be mentioned unto him" (Ezekiel 33:16)—remembered no more, so that we are free to keep becoming what God intended.

How It Blesses — The Miracle of Forgiveness

I have felt the miracle of forgiveness—not as an idea but as a weight lifting. There was an evening when, in answer to prayer, powerful spiritual sensations settled over me, and for a long while I wept in silence as they slowly ebbed away. What remained was not the fear of God's judgment but the freedom the scriptures promise. "Men are that they might have joy" (2 Nephi 2:25)—and I have learned that God did not give us repentance to keep us in misery, but to bring us home to that joy.

This is what sanctification feels like from the inside: not perfection achieved, but shame released, again and again, until standing before God without fear becomes the ordinary condition of the soul.

The commitment below is an invitation to trust that the same grace which pardons you is the power that is slowly remaking you.

How Will You Practice?

COVENANT

I will partake of the sacrament this week with one specific sin laid down, trusting the Lord's promise to remember it no more—and I will thank Him for the grace that is changing me.

SEEKER

I will notice one way I have already grown this year, and thank God for the quiet, line-upon-line work of His Spirit in me.

EXPLORE

I will set aside a few minutes this week to consider the possibility that I am not stuck—that I can genuinely change over time.

REFLECTION. *There is a difference between doing good and being good. Where is God's Spirit slowly turning the one into the other in you?*